deft timing and manoeuvre – seized control of the Indian National Congress, given it a new Constitution and structure, and managed to successfully draw together antagonistic groups, particularly Muslims and Hindus. By the mid-1920s, though, this was unravelling. His own physical health had also weakened, his body ravaged by his early experiments with fasting and dietary regimes (he had first used a fast for public ends in 1924), and by his imprisonment at Yeravda Jail between 1922 and 1924. At Sabarmati, he studied, and he wrote: he kept up his side of a vast personal correspondence, wrote hundreds of articles for his newspaper, completed his great history of his South African years, *Satyagraha in South Africa* (which he always considered the crucial twin to his more personal autobiography), and began 'The Story of My Experiments with Truth'.

In his mid-fifties, Gandhi had embarked on a period of reflection, which he hoped would give him new bearings. He wished to formulate his ideas, his ethics and his politics – hitherto worked out in the heat of the moment as responses to specific events and campaigns – into a more universal form, and to revise the inner content as well as the outer image of his own self. Even so, the narrative unfolded in a somewhat erratic way, as Gandhi described to his American publisher, the Christian priest John Haynes Holmes: 'I have to write from day to day. I have mapped out no fixed plan. I write every week as the past events develop in my mind on the day allotted for writing the weekly chapter.'* He allowed the chapters to be freely reprinted in other Indian newspapers, but he decided to reserve the copyright to publish them in book form – the first occasion on